

EPHESIANS

THE

EPISTLE OF S. PAUL, THE APOSTLE,

TO THE EPHESIANS.

PREFACE.

Ephesus was a famous city, the metropolis of Asia Minor, upon the Ægean Sea, now called the Archipelago. In it was the temple of Diana, one of the seven wonders of the world. S. Paul had staid there two years, and preached another year thereabouts. See Acts xx. The chief design of this Epistle was to hinder the Ephesians, and others in the neighbouring cities, from being seduced by false teachers, who were come among them. In the first three chapters he extols the grace of God, in mercifully calling the Gentiles. It was written when S. Paul was a prisoner; (see C. iv. 1. and vi. 20.) but whether during his first imprisonment, at Rome, an. 62, or in the latter imprisonment, as others judge about an. 65, is uncertain. Wi. —Ephesus was the capital of Lesser Asia, and celebrated for the temple of Diana, to which the most part of the people of the East went frequently to worship. But S. Paul having preached the gospel there for two years the first time, and afterwards for about a year, converted many. He wrote this Epistle to them when he was a prisoner at Rome, and sent it by Tychicus. He admonishes them to hold firmly the faith which they had received; and warns them, and also those of the neighbouring cities, against the sophistry of philosophers and the doctrine of false teachers, who were come among them. The matters of faith contained in this Epistle, are exceedingly sublime, and consequently very difficult to be understood. It was written about twenty-nine years after our Lord's ascension. Ch. — Ephesus was the chief city in Asia Minor, much given to superstitions, and not less to debauchery and libertinism. In it was the famous temple of Diana. S. Paul had preached in this place three years; (Acts xx.) so that all, both Jews and Gentiles, heard the word of the Lord, till he was driven away by Demetrius, the silversmith. At his departure, he left Timothy (1 Tim. i.) to maintain the purity of the gospel, and preserve them from the fables, which S. Paul had warned the Ephesians, would be introduced among them by rapacious wolves, and men talking perversely, to lead disciples after them. The Gentile converts held fast to the doctrines they had received from S. Paul: the Jews were the chief innovators. To the former the apostle writes this Epistle, praising their steadfastness, and instructing them more fully in

the hidden mysteries of faith, viz. redemption, justification, call of the Gentiles, predestination, and the glorification of Christ, and his body, the Church. In the fourth, and succeeding chapters, he exhorts them to the practice of morality, and to fulfill their respective duties of parents, children, masters, servants, &c. and finally reminds all the soldiers of Christ, to be armed with spiritual weapons against all the assaults of the devil. S. Jerom observes that this Epistle, especially the first three chapters, are intricate and difficult; probably owing to the sublimity of the subject. The last three contain the most interesting morality. Estius.

passim. See also Acts xviii. 19. et seq. and xix. 1. et sequ. — When Cardinal Pole was consulted by what method the obscure passages of S. Paul's Epistles could be best unfolded, he replied: Let the reader begin with the latter part, where the apostle treats of morality, and practise that which is delivered there; and then let him go back to the beginning, where points of doctrine are discussed with great acuteness and subtilty.

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EPHESIANS 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. S. Chrysostom takes notice, in his preface to this epistle, that the doctrinal part in the first three chapters is treated in a very sublime manner, with long periods and sentences, which makes the style more perplexed and the sense more obscure than in his other epistles. On this account I shall first give the reader a paraphrase as literal as I can, and then make some short notes on the difficulties in the text. Wi.

Ver. 3. Blessed be the God, who, through his Son Jesus Christ, made man, hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings and gifts; and by his grace, infused into our souls, has given us a title to a happy eternity in heaven. Wi. — In heavenly things; (in cœlestibus) i.e. all spiritual blessings for heaven, or for eternity. This is the object of all the blessings we receive from God; and we ought, according to the first intention of them, to refer them all to eternal or heavenly beatitude. S. Paul distinguishes the blessings which we receive in Jesus Christ from those bestowed upon the Jews, which were temporal and limited to this earth. Calmet. Ch.

Ver. 4-8. As by his eternal decree, according to the purpose of his good will and pleasure, he hath made choice of us to be his adoptive sons, and predestinated us to be saved and glorified by the merits and grace of his beloved Son, our Redeemer, without any merits of ours to the glorious praise and riches of his grace, by which he hath made us abound in all wisdom and true prudence. Wi.

Ver. 9. That he might make known to us, and to all men, the mystery of his will and pleasure in establishing his new law, of calling all Gentiles, as well as Jews, to believe in his Son, made man for us, in the dispensation of the fulness of times, (that is, at the time decreed from eternity) to establish, to accomplish, and, as it is in the Greek, to recapitulate all things in heaven and on earth, in Christ, and through him, and his merits; on earth, by fulfilling all the types, figures, and prophecies concerning the Messiah; and in heaven, by filling up the number of his elect. Wi. — The mystery of his will. The word mystery

signifies a secret, an unknown design. It was the will of God, to reveal to us the great design he had in the incarnation of his Son, viz. the formation of one great body of true adorers; composed, without distinction, of Jew and Gentile: till (v. 10) when the time appointed shall come, he will reunite and perfect in or under Christ this one body, composed of the Church triumphant, Angels and saints in heaven, and the Church militant upon earth. S.

Chrysostom, Estius, &c.

Ver. 11. In Christ we also are called by lot; i.e. to this happy lot, this share and state of eternal happiness, (he seems to speak with an allusion to the manner by which the lands of a temporal inheritance was distributed to the Israelites, in Palestine) that we (v. 12) who are saved, may be to the praise of his glory; might praise God for ever in the kingdom of his glory; particularly we Jews, who before hoped in the Messiah to come, and also you Gentiles, who now having heard the gospel, have believed in Christ, and who, together with all Christians, have been now sealed as it were with the holy Spirit of promise; i.e.

by the Spirit promised, and all those spiritual graces which are an earnest and pledge, which give us an assurance of our future glory and happiness. For our redemption from our sins, and in order to the acquired possession, to the possession of that glorious happiness which Christ, by his incarnation and death, hath acquired for us. Wi.

Ver. 13. In whom you were sealed, &c. Having been regenerated in baptism, you have received the Holy Spirit and the supernatural gifts which he communicates, by which he has, as it were, impressed upon you the seal of your sanctification and the pledge of your salvation. It is not an external impression, such as that by which soldiers are marked by their sovereigns, nor circumcision, as of old, but it is a mark within you—the grace with which you are filled—which shews itself outwardly by miraculous effects, &c. Calmet.

— Some refer these words, in whom you were sealed, to the sacrament of baptism; others to confirmation: both, with the sacrament of holy

orders, confer a character, or mark, of which S. Paul seems to speak whenever he speaks of God sealing us.

Ver. 15, &c. Wherefore . . . hearing of your constancy in the faith of Christ, and of your charitable love to all the saints, or faithful, I give always thanks to God; I pray that God may be more revealed to you, that the eyes of your heart may be enlightened, (v. 18) that you may know what ground you have to hope in the transcendent greatness of God's almighty power, who raised Christ from the dead, (v. 20) and set him on his right hand in heaven, above all the choirs and orders of blessed spirits, putting all things under his feet, making him, as man, head over all his Church militant on earth, and triumphant in heaven: which Church is his mystical body, who is filled all in all, (v. 23) or as others have translated, who filleth all in all; the sense is, that the glory of Christ, as head of all, is filled and increased by the salvation and happiness of all his chosen members, and of all his elect, to the end of the world. Wi.

Ver. 19. His power. The greatest exertion of the power of God, or that action by which he shewed his power most, is the resurrection from the dead, which he exercised in Christ, when he raised him from the tomb, and placed him over all the Angels of heaven; and which shall likewise be exercised over us all, when we too shall be raised from the dead, and constituted members of the triumphant Church, and rewarded with a share of glory proportioned to our merits. These are the hopes to which we are called.

Ver. 21. All principality. The Fathers agree that there are nine orders of blessed spirits, of which some are specified here; in the Epistle to the Colossians we have the order of thrones, to which if we add the cherubim, seraphim, Angels, and Archangels, we shall have nine. Calvin and other heretics strive to bring into doubt, and to corrupt many points of Catholic doctrine, sufficiently clear in holy writ, and sanctified by the general belief of the Universal or Catholic Church.

Ver. 22. As Christ is king, and yet men are kings also; so Christ is head of the Church, and yet man may be head thereof also. Jesus Christ is

bishop and pastor of our souls; (Heb. iii.) but is that a reason why there should be no other bishop and pastor of our souls?

Notes as to the style or expressions of S. Paul, in this chapter.

Ver. 3. With all spiritual blessings in heavenly places: lit. in heavenlies, [1] or celestials, which some expound and translate, in heavenly things; but this being expressed just before by spiritual blessings, it rather seems to be understood of the glory prepared for us in heaven, or in the heavenly mansions; in which sense it seems to me, according to the interpretation both of S. Jerom and of S. Chrys. in their commentaries on these words. Estius takes notice that the same expression, in the celestials, is used five times in this epistle, and in all of them signifies places above us. Wi.

Ver. 6. To the praise of the glory of his grace; i.e. unto the glorious praise or commendation of his grace. Wi.

Ver. 8. In all wisdom and prudence; which may be either referred to the wisdom and prudence of God, the giver of grace, or to the gifts of wisdom and prudence bestowed upon the elect. Wi.

Ver. 9. Which he hath purposed in him;[2] i.e. in Christ: but in the Greek the sense is, in himself; i.e. in God the Father, who sent his Son. Wi.

Ver. 10. In the dispensation of the fulness of times. It may perhaps be translated, at the appointed fulness of time, which is generally expounded to signify at the time decreed from eternity. — To establish (or restore) all things in Christ.[3] The Greek is to recapitulate, or, as the Prot. translation, to gather together all things in Christ; which S. Jerom expounds, by a fulfilling at once in Christ all the ancient figures and prophecies of the former law. Wi.

Ver. 14. The redemption of acquisition;[4] i.e. in order to the acquired possession, or to the obtaining of that glory which Christ, by redeeming us, hath acquired for us. Wi.

Ver. 23. Who is filled all in all.[5] In the Latin the words have a passive signification, is filled; in the Greek may be signified, who filleth all in all. Wi.

[1] V. 3. In cælestibus, en tois epouraniois, in supercælestibus. S. Jerom, (p.

324, tom. 4. nov. edit.) Spiritualia in cælestibus expectanda . . . thesaurizamus nobis in cælis. See S. Chrys. log. a. p. 765.

[2] V. 9. In eo; but in the Greek, en auto, in seipso.

[3] V. 10. Instaurare, anakephalaïosasthai, recapitulare. See S. Jerom, p. 330.

[4] V. 14. Acquisitionis, peripoïeseos. See S. Jer. and S. Chrys.

[5] V. 23. Qui omnia in omnibus adimpletur, panta en pasi pleroumenou; which may either be in the passive or middle voice. S. Jerom, in his exposition, (p.

337) expressly says: Non ait, qui omnia in omnibus adimplet, sed qui omnia in omnibus adimpletur . . . sicut ergo adimpletur Imperator, si quotidie ejus impleatur exercitus, sic dominus Jesus, &c. See S. Chrys. in Lat. edit. (p. 869) and in the Greek, (p. 776. lin. 31) dia panton oun pleroutai to soma, where the whole text requires a passive sense.

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EPHESIANS 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 1. He enlivened you, when you were dead. These words, he enlivened or restored to life, are necessary to express the literal sense and construction, as appears from the following fifth verse. by what is here translated offences, are commonly understood trespasses less grievous than by the word sins. Wi. —

God hath quickened you, or restored you to life; these words, expressed in v.

5, are understood in this: in some editions they are expressed. V.

Ver. 2. According to the course of this world, (i.e. the customs of this wicked corrupt world) according to the prince of the power of this air, of the spirit, &c.

meaning the devils, who are permitted to exercise their power upon the earth, or in the air. See Jo. xii. 10. xiv. 30. xvi. 11. Wi. — *Secundum sæculum mundi hujus*: according to the custom of this world. You were dead to the eyes of God, but you live in the eyes of the world: and how do you live? according to the maxims of the world, in idolatry, in crime, in corruption of manners.

Corrumpti et corrumpere sæculum est. Tacitus. Calmet.

Ver. 3. Among whom, &c. S. Jerom (p. 3) refers it to trespasses or sins. — Were by nature; not by nature according to the state of man's first creation in paradise, but by nature infected with original sin by the fall of our first parents.

— Even as the rest; that is, all mankind. Wi.

Ver. 4, &c. But God . . . hath raised us up together, both Gentiles and Jews, to life in Christ, remitting our sins by faith in him, and by the grace of our merciful Redeemer, by his pure mercy, not by any works of ours, nor merely by the works of the former law. — Hath made us in

a condition to sit together in heavenly places, to be hereafter crowned in heaven. Wi.

Ver. 5. Quickened us together in Christ. Faith, baptism, and grace, are pledges of our future resurrection and glorification in heaven. Our present conversion is also a kind of resurrection. The time is come, when the dead shall hear the voice of the Son of God, and those who hear shall live. S. Aug. upon S. John, No. 7.

Ver. 8. Faith is the beginning, foundation, and root of justification, and the first of all other virtues, without which it is impossible to please God. B.

Ver. 9. Not of works, as of our own growth, or from ourselves: but as from the grace of God. Ch.

Ver. 10. For we are his workmanship, not only as to our body and soul, but by a new creation in Christ Jesus, with a new heart by his grace. Wi. — S. Paul now compares our conversion to creation, to shew that we had been called and justified without preceding merit. In the same manner as the things which God has drawn out of nothing, cannot glory as if they had contributed any thing to their existence. S. Jerom. hic.

Ver. 11-12. Be mindful that as for you, who were Gentiles, who were called an uncircumcised people by the circumcised Jews, that you were without Christ, without the hopes or expectation of the Messias, alienated from the conversation of those who were God's elect people, and from the promises particularly made to them, that the Messias should be of their race: without God in this world, i.e. without the knowledge and the worship of God. But now by Christ, by believing in him, you who seemed to be afar off, are made near by his blood, (v. 13) by him who died for all; for he hath brought peace to all men, breaking down by his incarnation and death that wall of partition, that enmity betwixt the Jews and Gentiles, making them but one; abolishing that former law, of so many ordinances,[1] precepts, and ceremonies, by decrees, (which may signify by his divine decrees; or rather, as S. Jerom expounds it by the Greek, abolishing the old law and its precepts

by the precepts and doctrine of the new law) that he might reconcile to God both the Jews and Gentiles, that now they might be one mystical body, to wit, the Church of Christ, of which he is the head. Remember then that you are no longer strangers and foreigners, as you were when the Jews were the only elect people of God: now, by faith and hope, you are fellow-citizens with the saints and with all the elect people of God: you are built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets, (v. 20) who, by their prophecies concerning the Messias, and by their teaching and preaching of the gospel, are as it were subordinate foundation-stones under Christ, the chief founder and the chief corner-stone of his Church; in whom you also (Christians, at Ephesus, and all the faithful) are built up together, (v.

22) as parts of a spiritual edifice or temple, where God inhabits. Wi.

Ver. 14. Christ destroyed the enmity which, like a wall of separation, stood between Jew and Gentile, and united them into one people. He did this in his flesh, by his own blood, or the sacrifice he made of his flesh on the cross.

Calmet.

Ver. 19. You are no longer strangers with regard to God and his holy alliance.

You are no longer travellers and vagabonds, without a God, as you were before your conversion; not knowing to whom you belonged, nor finding in paganism either solid foundation or truth, neither hopes for this nor consolation for future life. But now you are become citizens of the same city as the saints, and domestics of the house of God. Calmet.

Ver. 20. The Church is in this place said to be built upon the apostles and prophets; why not then upon S. Peter?

[1] V. 11-12. Legem mandatorum decretis evacuans, ton nomon ton entolon dogmasi (dogmatibus) katargesas; i.e. says S. Jerom, (p. 344) præcepta legalia Evangelicis dogmatibus commutavit. See S. Chrys. p. 879. Lat. edit. in Savil. p.

787.

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EPHESIANS 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 1. For this cause I, Paul, the prisoner, &c. The sense seems to be, I, Paul, am a prisoner; otherwise the sense will be suspended, and interrupted by a long parenthesis till the 14th verse, where it is again repeated, "for this cause I bow my knees." Wi.

Ver. 2. If yet[1] you have heard. If yet doth not imply a doubt, but is the same as, for you have heard the dispensation.[2] This word, dispensation, is divers times taken by S. Paul to signify the manner by which a thing is done, or put in execution; the sense therefore here is, for you have heard how by the grace of God I have been made your apostle. Wi.

Ver. 3. The mystery, &c. By this mystery, he means what he has already mentioned in the last chapter and what he continues to speak of, to wit, that by the coming of Christ, and the preaching of his gospel, all both Jews and Gentiles, all nations should be united into one Church, by one and the same faith. Wi. — Mystery, &c. Revelation, the same as he mentions Gal. i. 12.; where speaking of his gospel, he says, For neither did I receive it of man, nor did I learn it, but by the revelation of Jesus Christ. This revelation seems to have regarded principally three things: 1. The redemption and justification of man by Jesus; 2. the vocation of the Gentiles; and thirdly, a positive command to announce the gospel to them. He speaks particularly of the second and third.

Estius. — Made known to me by revelation, and to the other apostles and prophets. Wi.

Ver. 5. As it is now revealed.[3] S. Paul, as both S. Jerom and S. Chrys. take notice, does not absolutely say that this mystery was not known, but only not known as it was afterwards to the apostles. For whether by this mystery we understand the incarnation of Christ, or the uniting of the Jews and Gentiles into one Church, we cannot doubt but both were revealed to Abraham, to David, to many prophets and just men in the time of the law; but now it was revealed and made known to all. Wi.

Ver. 6. That the Gentiles should be coheirs, &c. This is the mystery which was heretofore unknown, and now revealed. This is what the greatest part of the Jews could never be brought to believe, that the Gentiles should be equally sharers with them of God's promises and blessings. They were strangely scandalized that S. Peter should receive Cornelius, an uncircumcised man, into the same communion. On the like account they persecuted S. Paul. Wi.

Ver. 7. I am made a minister, &c. i.e. an apostle, to preach this same doctrine of the gospel of Christ. Wi.

Ver. 8. To me, the least of all the saints, (i.e. of the faithful) is given this mission by the grace of God, and power from the Almighty of working miracles, and other miraculous gifts from him, who created all things in order to enlighten[4]

or bring light to all men, that they may know and be convinced of the dispensation and manner in which God will have this mystery now made known and preached to all the world. Wi.

Ver. 9. The Lord has commanded me to teach and declare his wisdom, displayed at this time in the mystery of our redemption; a mystery, which for so many ages, nay even from all eternity, has been locked up in the breast of the Almighty, but which he has at length vouchsafed to reveal. Menochius.

Ver. 10. That the manifold wisdom of God, and his other divine perfections of mercy, of justice, &c. may be more known, and seen executed by the coming of his Son, according to his eternal decrees of sending a Redeemer, in whom they are to believe, and have a hope and confidence of their eternal salvation.

Wi.

Ver. 13. Wherefore, I beseech you, be not discouraged nor disheartened at my tribulations and persecutions on the account of the gospel, nor at your own, which ought to be a subject both for you and me to glory in.
Wi.

Ver. 14-15. For this cause I pray and bow my knees to the eternal Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, of whom all paternity (or fatherhood[5]) in heaven and earth is named. The Greek word oftentimes signifies a family, and therefore may signify, of whom the whole family in heaven and earth is named; and thus the sense will be, that God is not only the Father of his eternal Son, but (as not only the Latin text, but even the Greek may signify) of all angelical spirits in heaven, and of all men, especially Christians, made his adoptive sons in baptism. But here may be signified not only a family, but those in particular who are honoured with the name and dignity of fathers; so that the name which they have of fathers, or patriarchs, is derived from God the Father of all, and communicated to them in an inferior degree. This exposition is found in S.

Jerom, in Theodoret, Theophylact. S. John Damascen, &c. Wi. — All paternity, or the whole family; patria. God is the Father both of angels and men: whosoever besides is named father, is so named with subordination to him.

Ch.

Ver. 17. Christ dwelleth in us by his gifts, and we are just by those his gifts remaining in us; and not by Christ's proper justice only, as some modern innovators will have it. B. — And this not by faith only, but by faith rooted and founded in charity, which accomplishes all virtues. Ibidem.

Ver. 18. What is the breadth, &c. It is not expressed to what must be referred these metaphorical words of breadth, length, &c. Some expound them of the charity which in our hearts we ought to have for one another; others, of the love which Christ shewed towards mankind, in coming to redeem all. Wi. —

What, &c. This thought seems borrowed from Job xi: "Peradventure thou wilt comprehend the steps of God, and wilt find out the Almighty perfectly." The inspired writer then shews us how the Almighty is incomprehensible; for, says he, "God is higher than the heavens; and what wilt thou do? he is deeper than hell; and how wilt thou know? The measure of him is longer than the earth, and broader than the sea." The apostle, alluding to these words, prays that the Ephesians may have faith and charity sufficient to enable them to comprehend all that is comprehensible of God; as S. Dionysius explains it. But we are not hence to conclude, that there exists such a thing as dimension or size with regard to God, for he is a pure Spirit: but these expressions are merely metaphorical. For by breadth we are to understand his virtue and wisdom, which extend over all his creatures: (Eccl. i.) "he poured out wisdom upon all his works." By length is meant his eternal duration: (Ps. ci.) "but thou, O Lord, remainest for ever." By height we are taught the infinite superiority of his nature over ours: (Ps. cxii.) "The Lord is high above all nations." And by depth we are shewn the incomprehensibility of his wisdom: (Ecclesiastes) "Wisdom is a great depth; who shall find it out?" Hence it appears that the end of faith and charity is, that we may arrive at a perfect faith; which may know, as far as it is intelligible, the greatness of his wisdom, his eternal duration, &c. S. Tho.

Aquin. in Eph.

Ver. 19. That you may be filled unto all the fulness of God; i.e. that as God is full of love and charity for all, so may you in an inferior degree, according as you are capable, be filled with charity. Wi.

[1] V. 2. Si tamen audistis, eige, &c. Si tamen and eige do not here express a doubt, but an affirmation, the same as in Latin, si quidem. See S. Chrys. on the next chapter, v. 21. log. ig. p. 829. eige ouk amphiballantos esti, alla kai sphodra diabebaioumenou.

[2] Ibid. Dispensationem, oikonomian, rei gestæ administrationem.

[3] V. 5. Sicuti nunc, os nun.

[4] V. 8. Illuminare omnes, photisai pantas; not as God doth by interior illuminations, but by preaching.

[5] V. 14-15. Omnis paternitas, patria. See S. Jerom on this verse: Deus . . .

paternitatis nomen ex seipso largitus est omnibus . . . præstat cæteris ut patres esse dicantur. Theodoret, tom. 3. p. 305. Ed. Par. an. 1642. Alii patres, sive corporales, sive spirituales, desuper traxerunt appellationem: oi de alloi pateres . . . anothen ten prosegorian [i]ilkusan. See S. J. Damascen, l. 1. Ortho.

fid. c. ix. Ed. Bas. p. 32. touto de istion, &c. See Theophylactus, &c.

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EPHESIANS 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Here begins the second part of this epistle, in which he exhorts them to the practice of Christian virtues. Wi.

Ver. 4. In one hope of your vocation. The three great reasons that we have to love one another are contained in this verse, because we have but one body, of which Christ is the head. We are all animated by the same spirit, viz. the Holy Ghost, who is given to us all, and we all live in the same hope of eternal happiness. Calmet.

Ver. 5. This contains some more reasons why Christians should love one another. We are all the servants of the same God, believe the same mysteries, and receive the same sacraments, whoever may be the dispenser of them. —

One faith. As rebellion is the bane of commonwealths and kingdoms, and peace and concord the preservation of the same; so is schism, and diversity of faith or fellowship in the service of God, the calamity of the Church: and peace, unity, and uniformity, the special blessing of God therein. S. Cyprian, in his book on the unity of the Church, writeth thus: "One Church, for one is my dove. This unity of the Church, he that holdeth not, doth he think he holdeth the faith? He that withstandeth or resisteth the Church, he that resisteth Peter's chair, upon which the Church was built, doth he trust that he is in the Church?" And again, Ep. xl. "There is one God, and one Christ, and one Church, and one chair, by our Lord's voice founded upon Peter. To set up another altar, or to constitute another priesthood, besides the one altar and the one priesthood, is impossible. Whosoever gathereth elsewhere scattereth. It is adulterous, it is impious, it is sacrilegious, whatsoever is instituted by man to the breach of God's disposition. Get ye far from such men: they are blind, and leaders of the blind." S. Hilary also applies this text against the Arians thus:

"Perilous and miserable it is that there are now among them as many faiths as wills, and as many doctrines as manners; whilst modes of faith

are written as men will, or as they will, so are understood. Whereas the one truth teaches there is but one God, one Lord, one baptism, and also one faith: hence whilst more faiths are made, they begin by falling from that which is the only faith, and end in having no faith at all." S. Hilary, l. ad Constantium Augustum.

Ver. 7. To every one of us is given grace according to the measure of the gift of Christ. That is, as it hath pleased Christ to bestow his free gifts upon us; to shew, says S. Chrys. that it was not according to any merit of ours. The words also shew that Christ is the giver and author of graces, and consequently the true God. Wi. — We must endeavour by all means in our power to preserve this unity, especially by avoiding jealousy, or being envious of the graces which have been given to our neighbour; considering that they all proceed from the same God, who divides to each one as he pleaseth. Tirinus.

Ver. 8. He led captivity captive.[1] S. Jerom and others expound these words of Christ's delivering the pious souls that had died before his ascension, and which were detained in a place of rest which is called Limbus Patrum. — He gave gifts to men. Having delivered men from the captivity of sin, he bestowed upon them his gifts and graces. Wi. — Wherefore he, David, in Ps. lxxvii. makes use of these words, in order to shew that these gifts were gratuitous, and that no person had a right to complain that another had received more: after this the apostle proceeds to shew that Christ even descended to the lower parts of the earth, in order to teach us humility; whence he concludes that we ought to be humble and live in union with our brethren, which is the chief subject of the present chapter. Tirinus.

Ver. 9. Into the lower parts of the earth. This cannot signify into the grave only, especially since in that which we look upon as the apostles' creed, we first profess to believe that he was buried, and afterwards that he descended into hell. Wi.

Ver. 11. Some indeed he gave to be apostles, &c. It is said (1 Cor. xii. 28.) that God (even with the Greek article) gave some to be apostles, &c. and here it is said of Christ: another proof that Christ is the true God. Wi.

Ver. 13-14. Unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the age[2] of the fulness of Christ; that is, according to the measure of the full and perfect age of Christ.

Of the ancient interpreters, some expound this of what shall happen in the next world, after the resurrection, when all the elect shall have bodies every way perfect; and as some conjecture, (when all who rise by a happy resurrection) shall seem to be about thirty, of the stature and age of Christ when he suffered. But others, especially the Greek interpreters, understand this verse of a spiritual perfection in this life, by which the members of Christ's mystical body meet in the unity of faith, and increase in grace and virtue by imitating Christ, and following his doctrine and example. And this seems more agreeable to what follows: that we may not now be children, tossed to and fro by the wickedness,[3] of men. The Greek word, as S. Jerom observes, may signify by the deceit or fallacy of men; by illusion, says S. Aug. And S. Chrys.

tells us it is spoken by a metaphor, taken from those who cheat at dice, to gain all to themselves, to draw men into errors and heresies. Such, about that time, were the disciples of Simon the magician. Wi. — Every one must labour to become perfect in the state in which he is placed, by increasing in the knowledge and love of God, which knowledge and love of God constitute the full measure of a Christian. S. Chrysostom. — S. Austin also admits to another interpretation of this place, but prefers the former. According to him, it may mean: that all people, at the resurrection, will be raised in such a state as they would have had if they lived to the age of Christ, viz. thirty-three years. S.

Thomas. — This text of the apostle, assuring to the one true Church a perpetual and visible succession of pastors, in the ministry, successors of the apostles, warranted the holy Fathers in the early ages of the Church, as it does Catholics of the present day, to try all seceders by the most famous succession of the popes or bishops of Rome. See this in S. Irenæus, l. iii. c. 3.

Tertul. in præscript. Optatus. l. ii. cont. Parmen. S. Austin, cont. ep. Manic. c. iv.

Ep. 165 & alibi. S. Epiphan. hæres. 27.

Ver. 16. By what every joint supplieth, &c. S. Paul compares the Church and mystical body of Christ (as he does elsewhere) to a natural body, whose perfection depends on the harmony, union, and concurrence of all the different parts; and so in the Church, of which Christ is the head, some are apostles, some prophets, &c. and Christ hath been pleased to give them different offices, talents, and gifts, for the edifying and increase of the whole body, which is his Church, that they may no longer be like Gentiles, . . . alienated from the life of God; from such a life as God requires they should lead. Wi. —

The obscurity of this verse may be thus explained: the apostle compares the mystical body of the Church, of which Christ is the head, to the natural body of man; and as the head directs different members to different operations, according to their various properties, so in the Church Christ distributes to each his proper office, that being all intent upon their relative duties, all may grow up in charity and become perfect. Estius.

Ver. 19. Who despairing,[4] (without faith and charity) according to the Latin text and some Greek manuscripts; though according to the ordinary Greek, without grief or sorrow, (to wit, for their sins) have given themselves over to all manner of vices, unto covetousness.[5] Some take notice that the Greek word may not only signify avarice, or covetousness of money, but any unsatiable desires or lusts. See C. v. 3. and 5. Wi.

Ver. 26. Be angry, and sin not, as it is said Ps. iv. 5. Anger, as a passion of the mind, may proceed from a good motive and be guided by reason; as our Saviour, Christ, (Mark iii. 5.) is said to have looked about at the Jews with anger, i.e. with a zeal against their blindness and malice. — Let not the sun go down upon your anger. If moved to anger, return without delay to a calmness of mind and temper. Wi. — Be angry when reason or necessity compels you; but even then, so restrain your anger that you neither offend God nor scandalize your neighbour. Moreover, lay it aside as soon as you are able, so that the sun go not down upon your anger. Jansenius.

Ver. 29. That it may afford grace to the hearers; i.e. that your speech may contribute to their good and edification. Wi.

Ver. 30. Grieve not the Holy Spirit: not that the Holy Ghost can be contristated.

**It is a metaphor; and the sense is, sin not against the Holy Ghost. Wi.
— To contristate the Holy Spirit is a metaphorical expression, which signifies to offend God, or the Holy Ghost, who has sealed us by the sacraments of baptism and confirmation with particular marks, by which we shall be distinguished from others in the day of our retribution. SS. Chrysostom, Jerom, Ambrose, &c.**

[1] V. 8. Captivam duxit captivitatem. On which words S. Jerom: (p. 364.) Descendit ad inferna, et sanctas animas, quæ ibi detinebantur, secum ad cœlos victor deduxit. See 1 Pet. c. iii.

[2] V. 13. In mensuram ætatis plenitudinis Christi; eis metron elikias (ætatis vel staturæ) tou pleromatos tou Christou. See S. Aug. l. xxii. de Civ. Dei. c. xv. et seq. tom. vii. p. 678. S. Hierom in Epitaphio Paulæ. tom. iv. part 2. p. 685. S.

Chrys. hom. xi.

[3] V. 14. In nequitiâ hominum, en te kubeia, in fallaciâ: kubeia, est lusus aleæ.

See S. Chrys. p. 821. Ed. Sav.

[4] V. 19. Deperantes. The Latin interpreter seems to have read apelpikotes, as in some MSS. but in most other copies apelgekotes, indolentes. See S. Jer. in his Commentary, p. 368.

[5] Ibid. In avaritiam: en pleonexia, in cupiditate. See v. 3. of the next chapter.

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EPHESIANS 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 3. Covetousness.[1] The Latin word is generally taken for a coveting or immoderate desire of money and riches. S. Jerom and others observe, that the Greek word in this and divers other places in the New Testament may signify any unsatiable desire, or the lusts of sensual pleasures; and on this account, S. Jerom thinks that it is here joined with fornication and uncleanness. But S.

Chrys. in the last chapter, (v. 19. hom. xiii. and on this chap. v. 3.) shews that by the Greek word is understood avarice, or an immoderate desire of riches, when he tells (hom. xviii) that this sin is condemned by those words of Christ, Luke xvi. 13. You cannot serve God and mammon. Wi.

Ver. 4. Nor obscenity.[2] What is here meant by this word, S. Chrys. tells us at large in the moral exhortation after his 17th homily; to wit, jests with immodest suggestions or a double meaning, and raillery or buffoonery against the rules of good conversation, scarce made use of by any but by men of low condition and of a mean genius, which is not to the purpose of a Christian, who must give an account to God of all his words. Wi.

Ver. 5. Nor covetous person, which is a serving of idols. It is clear enough by the Greek that the covetous man is called an idolater, whose idol is mammon; though it may be also said of other sinners, that the vices they are addicted to are their idols. Wi.

Ver. 6. The apostle here puts them in mind of the general judgment, when the angel of God will, on account of their crimes of avarice, fornication, &c. fall on the children of unbelief; by which are meant the wicked. He had before assured them that the perpetrators of such crimes would be excluded from the kingdom of heaven; and now he moreover informs them, that the severest punishments will be inflicted on such wicked persons. Estius.

Ver. 7. Be ye not, therefore, partakers with them: do not imitate their wickedness, or the wrath of the Almighty will likewise fall on you. Estius.

Ver. 8. By darkness is here meant the state of infidelity into which they had been plunged so far as to adore stones as God, and committed without remorse the above-mentioned grievous sins. But delivered by Christ from this darkness, they have become light in the Lord, shining in faith and justice.

Estius.

Ver. 9. For the fruit of the light. So the Latin and divers Greek copies; not the fruit of the spirit, as we read in many Greek manuscripts; and in this Dr. Wells thought fit to change the Prot. translation. Wi.

Ver. 10. With solicitude seek out what things are pleasing to God, and carefully perform them. Estius.

Ver. 11. You are light, they are darkness; do you, therefore, shew by the light of your good works how base and detestable their works of darkness are. Estius.

Ver. 14. Rise, thou that sleepest. The sense may be taken from Isai. lx. 1. S.

Jerom thinks they may be cited from some work not canonical. Wi.

Ver. 23. For the husband is the head of the wife. Though S. Paul here speaks of a man, who is a husband, we may rather translate man than husband, being the same sentence and same words as 1 Cor. xi. 3. where even the Prot.

translation has, that the man is head of the woman. — He (Christ) is the saviour of his mystical body, the Church: though some expound it, that the husband is to save and take care of his wife, who is as it were his body. Wi.

Ver. 24. As the church is subject to Christ. The Church then, according to S.

Paul, is ever obedient to Christ: and can never fall from him, but remain faithful to him, unspotted and unchanged to the end of the world. Ch.

Ver. 26. Cleansing it by the laver^[3] of water, in the word of life. By this washing is generally understood the sacrament of baptism; and by the

word of life, not the word of the gospel preached, but the words or form used in the administration of baptism, according to Christ's institution: but this is not so certain. Wi.

Ver. 27. Not having spot or wrinkle. S. Aug. and others expound it of the glorious Church of Christ, in heaven: others even of the Church of Christ in this world, as to its doctrine, sacraments, and discipline, or practices approved by the Catholic Church. Wi.

Ver. 28-31. He that loveth his wife, loveth himself. S. Paul would have this a love like that which a man hath for himself, or for his own flesh, when they are now joined in wedlock, and are become as it were one flesh and one person, as to a civil life and society. See Mat. xix. 5. The wife is to be considered as a part of the husband, as a member of his body, of his flesh, and of his bones.

The words are to be taken with an allusion to what Adam said, (Gen. ii. 23.) This is now bone of my bones, &c. And so, according to the apostle, speaking figuratively, the Church, which is the spouse of Christ, is framed as it were of his bones and of his flesh sacrificed on the cross. Wi.

Ver. 32. This . . . sacrament, (or mystery) . . . in Christ, and in the Church. This sacrament, in construction, must be referred to what immediately went before, i.e. to the conjunction of marriage betwixt man and wife; and this is called a great sacrament, or mystery, as representing the union or spiritual nuptials of Christ with his spouse, the Church. Wi.

[1] V. 3 and 5. Covetousness, avaritia, pleonexia. See S. Jerom on these verses, who expounds it of an insatiable lust, as to the sins of uncleanness and impurity. p. 380. But see also S. Chrys. who, by pleonexia, (C. iv. 19.) expounds, an immoderate desire of riches: chrematon om. ig. p. 829. And here, hom. xvii. p. 847, o gar auto chrematon eromen, kai somaton. And hom. xviii, on the fifth verse, he expounds the word, pleonektes, os estin eidololatres, qui est idolatra, of him who is, properly speaking, an avaricious man; who adores mammon, or riches, who takes pains to leave an inheritance to others, and deprives himself of it, &c. p. 853. chruso douleuontes, 851.

[2] V. 4. Scurrilitas, quæ ad rem non pertinet, eutrapelia ta oukanekonta. S.

Chrys. log. ig. p. 848 and 849, describes the vice of eutrapelia in these words: entha aichrotes, ekei e eutrapelia . . . e eutrapelia malaken poiei psuchen,

&c. . . . porro touto christianou, to komodein . . . ei kalon to pragma, ti tois mimois aphietai; . . . parasiton to pragma, mimon, orcheston, gunaikon, pornon, porro psuches eleutheras, porro eugenous . . . ei tis aichros, outos kai eutrapelos. Where there is filthiness, there is eutrapelia. It is this that makes the mind effeminate . . . Far be it from a Christian to play the comedian. If this were commendable, why is it left to buffoons? It is the business of flattering hangers-on, or trencher friends, of fools in a play, of debauched women, but far be it from persons of a higher rank, well born, and of good breeding. If any man be void of honour, void of shame, such a one is given to eutrapelia. A man will scarce find it worth his while to consult the Latin translation in Fronto-Ducæus, which in this and many other places is far from being exact. I know that Aristotle, (l. iv. de moribus. c. 14, p. 42. Ed. Aurel. Allobrog.) and S.

Thomas, the doctor of the schools, (l. ii. Q. 60. a. 5. and 22. Q. 168. a. 2.) take eutrapelia in a different sense, when it is a facetious innocent way of jesting, containing rather instructive admonitions; and so, S. Thomas tells us, it may be reckoned among the moral virtues; but then, even as Aristotle tells us, it must be without all words of immodesty and buffoonery, which is against good manners: otherwise it degenerates into scurrility.

[3] V. 26. Lavacro aquæ in verbo vitæ, to loutro tou udatos en remati loutron, be taken for a bath of water, or the water itself. See Tit. iii. 5. Vitæ is now wanting in the Greek. See Estius. S. Chrys. by the word, understands the form of baptism in the name of the Father, &c. Hom. xx.

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EPHESIANS 6

CHAPTER VI.

Ver. 2. With a promise. This commandment being delivered with a special promise of a long life, which promise is to be understood conditionally, especially in regard to Christians, i.e. unless it be a greater favour to be taken out of the world young. Wi.

Ver. 5. Your carnal; temporal masters, whether Christians or heathens. Wi.

Ver. 6. Not serving to the eye; to please men only, but to do the will of God. Wi.

Ver. 9. Forbearing threatenings; forbearing, and remitting the punishments which you might perhaps threaten them with, and they deserve. Wi.

Ver. 12. Flesh and blood, which may either signify temptations of the flesh, or raised by mortal men. — Principalities and powers; i.e. devils, or apostate angels, who before their fall were in such ranks of spirits, and who are permitted to rule over the wicked in this world of darkness. Wi. — By which we are to understand the fallen angels. For as by nature, and from their creation, they were the governors of this corporeal world, and were deprived of this their power on account of their pride, they received it (though limited by certain restrictions) in order to tempt man. Estius. — Rulers of the world of this darkness. By these are meant the devils who exercise their power and authority in our inferior and dark atmosphere, by raising winds, storms, tempests, &c. By darkness may be understood the wicked, in whom Satan reigns as in a citadel. Menochius. — Our inferior world is called dark and misty in comparison of the world above, which is always bright, serene, and clear.

Our atmosphere is called the cloudy and dark heavenly. Cicero, in his Tuscul Quæst. Prudentius likewise, in Hamartigenia, writes thus: Non mentem sua membra premunt, nec terrea virtus

Oppugnat sensus liquidos, bellove laccessit;

Sed cum spiritibus tenebrosis nocte dieque

Congredimur quorum dominatibus humidus iste

Et pigris densus nebulis obtemperat aer.

Scilicet hoc medium cœlum inter et infima terræ

Quod patet ac vacuo nubes suspendit hiatu,

Frena potestatum variarum sustinet, ac suo

Principe Belial rectoribus horret iniquis.

His colluctamur prædioribus, at sacra nobis

Oris Apostoli testis sententia prodit. — Estius.

— Against the spirits of wickedness: or wicked spirits in the air, says S. Jerom.

Lit. in celestials. Wi. — High places. That is to say, in the air, the lowest of the celestial regions in which God permits these wicked spirits or fallen angels to wander. Ch.

Ver. 14. Your loins . . . with truth, both as to doctrine and a good life, keeping your baptismal promises. — Having on the breastplate of justice, not only of the particular virtue of justice, but of all virtues in general. Wi.

Ver. 15. Your feet shod with the preparation of the gospel; i.e. prepared to walk in the ways of the gospel, as a soldier must be prepared and in readiness to march or to fight. Wi.

Ver. 16. The shield of faith. A lively faith working by charity, which will enable you to conquer your greatest enemies, and to escape their fiery darts, their greatest temptations, and attacks. Wi.

Ver. 24. Who love our Lord Jesus Christ. Lit, "in incorruption;" with purity of heart and mind. Wi.

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